SOLITARY RETREAT

EREMOS PLACE

sol·i·tar·y | *sälə terē*

› done or existing alone

re·treat | *rə trēt*

› withdraw to a quiet or secluded place

Before you is a gift—the gift of solitude. Have you ever spent two hours in a solitary place? Here is the challenge: get a Bible, get a journal, and get alone. This guide was made to take you on a two-hour journey of quiet time alone with God. If you finish early, re-read some of the passages for deeper reflection—or if you go over, even better.

Make this time your own. It's your relationship with Christ. Consider using this guide to catapult you into even more extended quiet time—bring a book you've wanted to start, curate a playlist, or build off the rhythm of Bible reading, prayer and silence through other passages.

A FEW GUIDELINES TO SET UP YOUR TIME

1. Find a quiet, uninterruptible place.
2. Leave your technology in an unreachable place. If you need a phone, put it on silent or airplane mode.
3. This is not a guide you need to *get through*, but a guide to help you *lean in* and hear from the Lord.
4. The Holy Spirit is your guide. Let Him lead your thoughts, prayers, journaling, Bible reading, and silence.
5. Success is not determined by what you receive from God, but by the disciplined obedience of getting time alone with Him.

I pray that—however much time you can carve out—this experience lets you taste what God's people have tasted for generations: that it is good to be near God.

> *"But as for me, it is good to be near God."*
>
> PSALM 73:28

Hear Jesus' call. He is inviting you. Come rest.

> *"Come with me by yourselves to a quiet place and get some rest.' So they went away by themselves in a boat to a solitary place."*
>
> MARK 6:31-32

REST 30 MINUTES

PREPARE your time by journaling your thoughts. Write down your worries, your to-do's, your wants, your desires—anything that comes to mind. You are emptying your mind to receive from the Holy Spirit today.

REST your mind by praying to God. Ask Him to prepare your heart and mind.

READ 15 MINUTES

READ Luke 5:16, Luke 4:1, and Mark 6:31–32.

- What do you observe? Journal your thoughts.

REFLECT 30 MINUTES

WRITE out Luke 5:16, Luke 4:1, and Mark 6:31–32, taking note of every word. What do you see?

Luke 5:16 says, "Jesus often withdrew to lonely places and prayed." The Greek word translated *lonely* is **EREMOS**—the same word translated *wilderness* or *desert* in Luke 4:1, and the same word used in Mark 6:31 when, after a busy day of ministry, Jesus invites His disciples to "come with me by yourselves to a quiet place (eremos) and get some rest."

Lonely, desert—most of us exert a lot of energy avoiding these places, but here you are in a quiet place. All of these passages have this one word in common: *eremos*. Jesus got away often to spend quiet time with God alone, and in some cases invited His disciples to join Him.

- What do Jesus' habits in Luke 5:16 teach us?
- How might this inform your walk with Christ?

READ Mark 1:35–37. Where did the disciples find Jesus? Now read Mark 1:32–34—what was Jesus up to the night before? We can make a lot of excuses when it comes to prayer, but for Jesus it was a way of life. Communicating with His Father was a priority.

REFLECT CONTINUED

READ Psalm 5:3. The Psalmist writes of the benefits of spending daily quiet time with the Lord. What does this verse tell us we should do? What does it suggest God does in response?

REVERE 15 MINUTES

SILENCE. Hopefully you are somewhere silent. Take your earbuds out. If you aren't used to getting silent before the Lord this could feel strange—embrace it. Let your reverence of God lead you to worship. Take the next 15 minutes and be still.

> *"Be still, and know that I am God."*
> PSALM 46:10

RESPOND 30 MINUTES

PRAYERFULLY consider the following. Jesus often withdrew in order to submit to His Father's timing, direction and will (Luke 6:12, Luke 22:39–46).

- What would it look like in your life if, like Jesus, you made it a priority to slip away often for extended prayer? Describe it in practical terms.
- What distracts you from having eremos time with God?
- How could you create a daily eremos place—"your spot" to meet with the Lord?

FURTHER READING

Psalm 119 · Luke 9:18–27 · Luke 11:1–13 · Luke 22:39–46

NEXT STEPS

1. Set a reminder a few days from now to reflect back over your journaled thoughts. Following up on what God teaches us is how we learn best.
2. Pick a date and time on the calendar for your next solitary retreat. If you don't plan it, life will once again rush by.
3. Be intentional with what the Lord spoke to you today. Find at least one meaningful way this will change your day-to-day life.